The Commit

No. 001 · Vol. 1
Tuesday, 27 October 2026
Twice weekly · Mon & Thu

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01 · PRIVACY

Google opens personal AI data to ad targeting

Connecting Gmail, Drive or Photos for personalized search can also make that information available for personalized advertising.

src: theverge.com · 2 min read

Google has changed its privacy policy to allow information from Gmail, Drive and Google Photos to inform personalized advertising when users share it with other Google services. The Verge reports that an exception added on October 16 changes an earlier promise against using that content for targeted ads. The change matters to people who connected those services to Search through Personal Intelligence.

That feature lets search tools draw on personal information to offer more useful responses and recommendations. Under the revised terms, Search may process some of the information users allow it to access to personalize content, including advertising. The connection that improves an AI answer can therefore also shape which commercial messages appear alongside the wider Google experience.

The policy does not give advertisers access to the underlying files, messages or personally identifying details. Google also says it will not target ads using sensitive categories such as health or religion. Users who want to prevent this use can disconnect individual apps from Search's Personal Intelligence features or disable Personalized Recommendations in Search Services Personalization settings. The practical decision is now about advertising as well as convenience.

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02 TECH NEWS

OpenAI science claims face outside scrutiny

OpenAI has announced claimed discoveries in mathematics, computer science and physics, while bringing outside specialists into the process of examining and explaining some results. The Verge reports that an independent computer science group including Russell Impagliazzo, Ramamohan Paturi and Ryan Williams will scrutinize a claimed refutation of the Exponential Time Hypothesis. At that group's request, the AI write-up and a Lean proof were made public. OpenAI also describes a rigorous existence proof involving quantum field theories, but the physics work has not been released in full. David Gross is to lead its expert group. These are consequential claims awaiting examination; the announcement and named reviewers do not themselves establish that the proofs are correct.

src: theverge.com

Brotli flaw requires patches and restarts

A flaw in Google's reference C decoder for Brotli compression can cause crashes, memory leaks or remote code execution, according to the Broccoli2Shell advisory. It affects decoder versions 1.0.3 through 1.2.0 and can be reached when software decompresses attacker-controlled data. That includes ordinary HTTP clients that automatically decode compressed responses, not just applications explicitly opening archives. Node.js bundles its own decoder, while Python clients can use installed Brotli packages without an application importing them directly. Updating a system library therefore will not repair every private copy. The advisory stresses that running processes need restarting, and containers need rebuilding on patched bases and redeployment. Updating Express alone does not fix the underlying decoder.

src: broccoli2shell.com

03 TECH RADAR

Authenticator token flaw patched

Microsoft patched an Android Authenticator flaw that researchers say let installed malicious apps impersonate trusted applications and obtain work-account tokens without user approval.

src: cybersecuritynews.com

Fitbit battery becomes replaceable

DC Rainmaker's Fitbit Edge review identifies a user-serviceable battery, the first in a Fitbit-branded product, alongside a larger screen and physical side button.

src: dcrainmaker.com

Election images get cartoon treatment

ChatGPT now steers images depicting election interference or discouraging voting into illustrated styles, CNET reports, reducing the realism available for that category of political imagery.

src: cnet.com

04 TECH NEWS CONTINUED

Robot dog sale divides Boston Dynamics

More than 300 Boston Dynamics employees signed a petition urging executives to halt a sale of robot dogs to US Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Ars Technica reports. Executives defended the deal and said the robots would not be weaponized. A $1.3 million Homeland Security contract with Radeco covers four modified Spot robots, marketed as Cerberus. The contract describes radiation, toxic gas and explosive detection, remote inspection and work against cross-border tunnels and trafficking networks. Employees argue that supplying ICE creates unacceptable risks, citing its enforcement operations. Boston Dynamics says the machines can keep people safe. The dispute puts a concrete procurement decision behind a broader question: how much responsibility robot makers retain for customers' uses.

src: arstechnica.com

Ukraine disputes Musk's Starlink accusation

Elon Musk accused Ukraine of using civilian Starlink for lethal drone strikes in violation of its terms, while Ukrainian officials disputed that account. Ars Technica reports that the argument followed satellite restrictions affecting drones above certain speeds. Ukrainian officials said previous controls already prevented the alleged use of the commercial service, and that moving drone terminals instead required the US-controlled military Starshield system. President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the new restrictions had been lifted and necessary speeds restored. Officials have sometimes used Starlink and Starshield interchangeably, complicating interpretation of their statements. The conflicting accounts leave the precise service involved disputed, while demonstrating the operational consequences when military communications depend on privately supplied satellite infrastructure.

src: arstechnica.com

05 TECH RADAR CONTINUED

Cargo thieves spoof tracking

Investigators described hacked freight accounts and spoofed GPS tracking in data-centre cargo thefts; NBC sources put losses above $100 million since June, Ars reports.

src: arstechnica.com

Acer handheld reaches America

Acer's first officially launched US gaming handheld, the Predator Atlas 8, arrives November 1 at $1,299.99, with an eight-inch display and Windows 11.

src: theverge.com

Early foldable screens fail

Some iPhone Duo buyers report internal OLED failures within hours of use, Ars reports. The accounts establish early defects, without measuring how widespread they are.

src: arstechnica.com

06 SEMICONDUCTORS Fri 23 → Tue 27 Oct

LITHOGRAPHY

Larger masks gain a roadmap

A 2031 pilot target leaves supply-chain challenges ahead.

src: semiengineering.com · 2026-10-26

TSMC and ASML have announced an initiative targeting a 12-inch lithography mask pilot line by 2031, Semiconductor Engineering reports. Masks carry chip patterns; the proposed six-by-twelve-inch format doubles their area.

Panelist Harry Levinson estimates roughly 40 percent better productivity from exposing a larger field in High-NA extreme-ultraviolet systems without joining separate exposures. This is a projected benefit, not a commercial production result.

Larger multilayer blanks, cleaning processes and protective pellicles must all be ready together. More area increases contamination risks, and some critical links have only one supplier. The roadmap sets a shared timetable, with substantial development still needed before routine manufacturing.

07 CHIP BRIEFING

Vertical memory explores a cooler arrangement

Imec researchers evaluated DRAM dies rotated vertically above a GPU, with cooling cavities between them. Package-level thermal simulations explored memory capacity, stack height, materials and orientation. The work examines an alternative to conventional high-bandwidth memory layouts; it describes a simulated design space rather than a new memory stack entering commercial production.

src: semiengineering.com

Photonics testing needs more than electrical probes

Silicon photonics adds precise light coupling and polarization control to conventional electrical testing. Semiconductor Engineering describes automated alignment as a potential production bottleneck, requiring cooperation across equipment suppliers. Advantest and FormFactor have collaborated on a wafer-level test environment. Repeatable optical testing is part of scaling manufacturing, beyond demonstrating a working device.

src: semiengineering.com

Stacked transistors confront heat and wiring

Researchers at TU Munich and IIT Kanpur compared four-tier and conventional two-tier complementary transistor designs using simulations calibrated to experimental measurements. Their study examines self-heating and unwanted resistance and capacitance from interconnects. It highlights constraints on stacking more devices vertically; the reported work is modeling, rather than evidence of commercial four-tier production.

src: semiengineering.com

08 EXPLAINER full piece ~3 min

LANGUAGE EQUITY

The same AI task can cost more by language

How text is divided into tokens changes the price, speed and usable memory of multilingual AI.

src: restofworld.org · 2026-10-26

An AI service can charge the same price per token while imposing very different costs on speakers of different languages. Tokens are the units of text or data a model processes. A tokenizer breaks the input into those units, and some languages need many more units to express comparable material. Rest of World reports on research calling this a hidden tokenizer tax.

The Coalition for Language Equity in AI Research found gaps even among the twenty most popular internet languages. The most expensive used between 1.5 and five times as many tokens as the cheapest. Expanding the comparison to 200 languages widened the disparity: in one model, the gap reached seventeen times. These are findings from the study, rather than a universal multiplier applying to every model or task.

The consequences extend beyond a bill. More tokens mean more processing and less room for documents or conversation history within a model's available context. Pratyush Choudhury of Activate AI, which backs multilingual voice startups, uses tutoring as an example: a service needs to retain earlier mistakes and explanations. If one language fills that space faster, the disadvantage can affect the lesson itself.

A language's number of speakers does not fully explain the pattern. Script matters. The study found Asturian benefited from using Latin script and from related Romance languages, despite having relatively few speakers. Languages using scripts rarely encountered by tokenizers, including Burmese and Tibetan, were consistently disadvantaged across nearly all the models analyzed.

Better digital data could improve model quality, but Maya Research chief Dheemanth Reddy argues that data alone will not repair tokenization. Labs must deliberately design tokenizers for underserved scripts. Falling token prices may soften direct costs while leaving relative disadvantages. Choudhury proposes language scorecards comparing the cost of completing equivalent tasks successfully, making efficiency a product requirement alongside accuracy, speed and reliability.

BYTE-SIZED JOKE

My smart fridge asked for more context. Apparently, "something for dinner" exceeded its available shelf space.

09 COMPANY ACTIONS Fri 23 → Tue 27 Oct

Microsoft offers mass buyouts

Microsoft will offer buyouts to roughly 60,000 eligible workers, about a quarter of its workforce, CNBC reports via Ars. Selected teams in the US, India, Canada and UK qualify. Microsoft gave no direct reason. The offer follows a smaller retirement program amid cost management and spending on AI infrastructure.

MICROSOFT · arstechnica.com

iPad mini adds OLED

Apple announced an iPad mini with an 8.5-inch OLED screen and A20 Pro processor. Prices start at $699 for Wi-Fi and $849 with cellular. Preorders open October 28; availability begins November 6. Apple claims a thinner, lighter design with water and dust resistance. Performance comparisons await independent testing.

APPLE · apple.com

Siri remembers past conversations

Apple's operating-system update 27.2 adds Siri conversation memory and access to voicemails and Messages attachments, Ars reports. Excluded Apps controls access by Siri, Search and suggestions. Siri AI gains French, Japanese, Korean, Portuguese and Spanish, but remains unavailable in the EU and mainland China. Broader personal context comes with access controls.

APPLE SOFTWARE · arstechnica.com

Anthropic discloses gas risks

Anthropic's listing filing says some planned data centres rely on on-site gas turbines, The Verge reports. It warns that gas and pipeline competition could raise prices or delay projects. Rising temperatures could increase power and cooling costs. The disclosures identify infrastructure risks, rather than confirming new capacity is operating.

ANTHROPIC · theverge.com

NBA signs prediction-market deals

The NBA signed preferred prediction-market deals with Kalshi and Polymarket and expanded its DraftKings relationship, The Verge reports. Partners gain official data and intellectual property, subject to market limits and suspicious-trade information sharing. Amid basketball gambling cases, a new integrity framework accompanies the deals and a memorandum with the US commodities regulator.

NBA · theverge.com

Trainium shifts training software

Amazon is shifting Trainium toward native PyTorch training, SemiAnalysis reports after trying Trainium3 racks. Familiar tools address friction for researchers changing model architectures. The analysts report bugs and say the ecosystem remains less mature than Nvidia's CUDA. Their favorable assessment concerns software direction, without establishing broad adoption or universal performance superiority.

AMAZON · newsletter.semianalysis.com

10 COMPANY ACTIONS CONTINUED Fri 23 → Tue 27 Oct

Tesla looks beyond car sales for growth

Tesla is pursuing a larger role for AI and software in its business while cars still generate 75 percent of revenue, Ars Technica reports. Its supervised Full Self-Driving product has 1.7 million active subscriptions globally, up 67 percent from a year earlier. Despite the name, that version requires an attentive human driver. The company has not won approval for its fully autonomous version. Wider European backing for supervised FSD faces a member-state vote delayed until December. Analysts see software as a possible profit driver, but that outlook depends on adoption and regulatory decisions rather than the subscription figures alone.

TESLA · arstechnica.com

OpenAI adds a cheaper midrange model

OpenAI released GPT-6.1 Terra, priced at $1 per million input tokens and $5 per million output tokens, The Register reports. That is half GPT-6.1 Sol's standard API prices and one-tenth GPT-6 Astra's. OpenAI presents the model as an option for high-volume work such as processing invoices. Artificial Analysis describes it as improving cost efficiency, while an OpenAI staff member says capabilities vary by task. Lower prices expand the choices for organizations automating routine work, but the available comparisons do not establish that Terra replaces more expensive models equally well across every kind of job.

OPENAI · theregister.com

11 MARKETS 23 Oct → 26 Oct

S&P 500	NASDAQ	EURO STOXX 50	BITCOIN
▲ +0.7%	▲ +0.8%	▲ +0.8%	▼ −1.3%
7,677	26,169	6,116	80,007

▲ BIGGEST GAINERS

+6.2%	Arm ARM	$223
+5.2%	Tesla TSLA	$392
+4.0%	Intel INTC	$90.47

▼ BIGGEST LOSERS

−3.0%	Netflix NFLX	$63.90
−3.0%	Coinbase COIN	$160
−1.9%	Meta META	$631

Change between daily closes · finance.yahoo.com · not investment advice

12 WORLD REPORT Fri 23 → Tue 27 Oct

Oleshky truce aims to open aid route

A limited truce has begun in Russian-occupied Oleshky, with Ukrainian officials and Russia's defence ministry saying it is being respected. The BBC reports that it is intended to allow aid and civilian evacuation on Friday. Ukraine estimates around 6,000 people remain in the city and surrounding areas. Residents describe extreme hunger; evacuation arrangements and independent verification of implementation remain uncertain.

UKRAINE · bbc.co.uk

Nyala drone strike kills at least 21

A drone strike on a market in Sudan's Nyala killed at least 21 people and injured more than 40, a hospital medic told AFP, according to Al Jazeera. The city serves as the Rapid Support Forces' de facto capital. Both sides increasingly use drones in the civil war, while international governments have called for urgent action to prevent famine.

SUDAN · aljazeera.com

India evacuates coast before Cyclone Arnab

India is moving tens of thousands of people as Cyclone Arnab approaches Andhra Pradesh and Odisha. Nearly 50,000 had reached shelters in Andhra Pradesh by Monday night, its disaster authority said. Forecasters expect landfall Wednesday morning, with sustained winds of 115–125 kilometres an hour. More than 12 million people live along the projected path, according to the state authority.

INDIA · aljazeera.com

Bolsonaro challenges defeat amid travel ban

Flavio Bolsonaro said a Supreme Court justice ordered him to surrender his passports after he lost Brazil's presidential election. France 24 reports that Lula won 51.8 percent against Bolsonaro's 48.2 percent. Bolsonaro refused to concede and vowed to challenge the result. He is under investigation over alleged corruption and money laundering linked to a film about his father; he denies wrongdoing.

BRAZIL · france24.com

Israel votes in tight coalition contest

Israelis are voting in an election shaped by security and democracy. The BBC reports that Friday's polling put Benjamin Netanyahu and former military chief Gadi Eisenkot almost level, with neither bloc projected to reach the 61 seats needed for a majority. Coalition negotiations could be lengthy. Opposition parties have pressed for an independent inquiry into the October 7 attacks.

ISRAEL · bbc.co.uk

Vučić concedes to student protest movement

Serbia's Aleksandar Vučić admitted defeat in snap parliamentary elections to a student-led movement. Preliminary election commission figures gave the students 52.7 percent and his Serbian Progressive Party 39.2 percent, the BBC reports. The movement emerged after the Novi Sad railway station canopy disaster and fielded candidates from across society. The result follows two years of protests over corruption and negligence.

SERBIA · bbc.co.uk